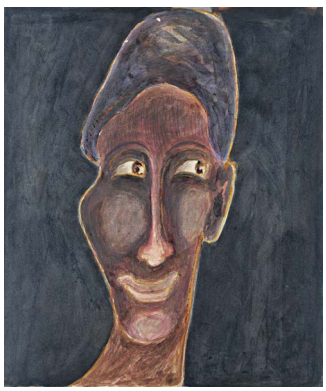
ART

A Tale of Two Cities

West Bengal finally has a **biennale** *of its own, currently being held in Santiniketan and Kolkata*

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LAYERS OF TIME *Clockwise from above, Rabindranath Tagore's 'Head of a Man'; Abanindranath Tagore's 'Sindbad the Sailor'; Dayanita Singh's 'Museum of Tanpura'*

For a long time, the idea of a Bengal biennale was one of a dream deferred. When curator Siddharth Sivakumar visited the Kochi Biennale as a student, he remembered having that wistful thought, "When will Bengal have its own biennale?" It was a dream that was set aside for later, for Malavika and Jeet Banerjee, directors of corporate branding agency Gameplan, and known for establishing the Kolkata Literary Meet in 2012. But lest it slip away, they booked the domain name of Bengalbiennale.com barely a couple of years after KALAM the lit-fest began.

The first-of-its-kind Bengal Biennale finally kicked off on November 29 at Santiniketan (where it will continue till December 22) and on December 6 in Kolkata (where it will continue till January 5, 2025). It's being held across 20 venues in the two cities, and involves over 100 artists, performers, scholars, curators and cultural practitioners. "We knew what we were working towards and to bring the spotlight on Santiniketan—Bengal's epicentre of art—was always the plan. But the word 'biennale' was something we were almost afraid to say out loud. You cannot unsay the word after saying it," says Sivakumar. As artists, galleries and exhibitions were added to the roster, it dawned on the organisers that it would become nearly impossible to do this every year. "And it sort of organically became a biennale," adds Sivakumar.

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Day one at Santiniketan featured artist Nikhil Chopra's 10-hour-long live performance 'Land Becoming Water' at GABAA, and mythologist Devdutt Pattanaik's exhibition *MYtruTH* at the newly opened space Tokaroun (by K.S. Radhakrishnan's Musui Art Foundation). The theme of the biennale is *Anka-Banka: Through Cross-Currents*. *Anka-banka* means 'meandering' (one only needs to look at the logo of the biennale to understand its meaning) and both Pattanaik's black-and-white line drawings and Chopra's performance invite its audience to wander and wonder.

The art, artist, venue and even narrative line-up is diverse—from economist Abhijit Banerjee and artist and graphic novelist Sarnath Banerjee's project 'Water Tells/Water Tales' at Mitali Homestays in Santiniketan to Dayanita Singh's 'Museum of Tanpura' (at the Indian Museum, Kolkata), Aradhana Seth's 'Sadak: Jaile Baire, The Jail and The World' (The Alipore Museum), and many more.

Of course, the horizon of Bengal and perhaps Indian art will always feature luminaries like the Tagores. The Victoria Memorial Hall will see *Between Home & The World: Arabian*